

MIG-2

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-2

Age: 28

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Venezuela

Host country: Colombia

Years in host country: 4

Occupation: Construction Worker

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I fled Venezuela four years ago when the crisis made it impossible to feed my family. The hyperinflation was so extreme that the money I earned in the morning was worth almost nothing by the evening, and our savings, everything we had worked years to build, simply evaporated overnight. Medicine became an unaffordable luxury, and even basic food was scarce and rationed. Colombia was the closest option, and we share a language and a long history, so I crossed the border on foot with little more than a backpack and a desperate hope for something better. I walked for days along with countless others doing exactly the same thing. Leaving was not a choice made freely; it was survival, the only path left when staying meant watching my children go hungry.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: For me, inclusion means being allowed to work legally and to access basic services like healthcare and my children's schooling without being treated as a criminal or an intruder. It is not about charity or handouts; it is about being given a fair chance to rebuild my life through my own effort and with dignity intact. When people see me as a worker who contributes, who pays for what he takes and asks only for the opportunity to earn his keep, rather than as an invader who has come to steal what belongs to others, that is inclusion. It means being judged by my actions and my character, not by the accent that immediately marks me as Venezuelan the moment I open my mouth.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Xenophobia here is very real and I confront it regularly. Many people blame Venezuelans for the rise in crime and for taking jobs and depressing wages, as though we arrived by choice rather than fleeing collapse. I have been insulted openly in the street, told to go back to my own country as if I had abandoned it on a whim, and some employers deliberately pay us less than Colombians because they know we are desperate and unlikely to complain. One man once spat that we Venezuelans were ruining his country, and I wanted to tell him that we had lost our own country, that no one understands displacement more painfully than those who have lived it. It is exhausting to carry the weight of a whole nation's reputation on your shoulders.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The biggest challenge by far was regularising my immigration status. Without documents, I could not obtain a proper, protected job, open a bank account, or access services in any secure way. For a long time I worked informally, exploited and entirely unprotected, with no recourse if an employer cheated me or an injury left me unable to work. Getting the temporary protection permit eventually changed everything, it opened doors that had been firmly shut, but the process itself was long, confusing, and full of bureaucratic obstacles that seemed designed to wear you down. There was also the constant anxiety of not knowing whether we would be allowed to stay, of building a life on ground that might shift beneath us at any moment.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: Construction work is physically demanding and unforgiving, and some of my Colombian coworkers resented us at first, genuinely fearing that we would take their jobs or drive down what they could earn. But over time, when they saw that I worked hard, showed up reliably, did not cause trouble, and pulled my weight without complaint, many of them came around and accepted me. A few even became good friends who went out of their way to help me find better opportunities and warned me away from employers known to exploit migrants. The shared experience of hard physical labour under the same sun has a way of dissolving suspicion; on a building site, what matters in the end is whether a man does his job well.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I hold onto my Venezuelan identity fiercely through our music, especially the songs that remind me of home, through our food like arepas and hallacas that I cook whenever I can afford the ingredients, and through my accent, which I refuse to hide or soften even though it marks me instantly. But I have also grown to genuinely love Colombia, which gave me refuge when I had absolutely nowhere else to go and no one to turn to. My heart now belongs to both nations, torn between them but grateful to each. I want my children to remember where they came from, to know the country of their birth, while also embracing the country that took them in and gave them a future.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: The news here constantly links Venezuelan migrants to crime, running story after story that paints all of us with the same brush, as though every one of the millions who crossed the border were a threat. The overwhelming majority of us are honest people simply trying to survive and provide for our families through legitimate work. This kind of coverage makes ordinary Colombians fearful and hostile toward us, and it has cost me real opportunities, jobs I did not get simply because of the reputation the media manufactured for my entire people. I wish they would tell the other stories too: the Venezuelan doctors, teachers, nurses and labourers who are contributing to this country every day, quietly and without recognition.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: There were some NGO programmes that helped enormously with food, temporary shelter, and legal advice when I first arrived with nothing. They were a genuine lifeline in those first desperate weeks and months, and I do not know how we would have survived without them. However, the government's

own integration efforts felt insufficient given the sheer scale of the migration, given how many hundreds of thousands, even millions of us crossed in a short span of time. The system was simply overwhelmed. Greater coordination between the charities doing the frontline work and the state, along with more resources directed toward regularisation and integration, would have helped enormously and would help those still arriving today.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children are enrolled in a Colombian school now, and they are doing well academically, though they faced real bullying at first because of their accents and because the other children knew they were Venezuelan. It broke my heart to see them come home upset, but they are resilient, more resilient than I sometimes think I would be in their place, and they are gradually making friends and finding their footing. Seeing them laugh and play like normal, carefree children again, after everything we went through, after the hunger and the fear and the long walk to the border, gives me the strength to endure the hardships and indignities I still face every single day at work and in the street.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: Reducing xenophobia requires leaders and politicians to speak responsibly and to stop scapegoating migrants for every social and economic problem the country faces. When those in power blame us publicly for crime and unemployment, ordinary people follow their lead and feel justified in their hostility. We badly need public campaigns that show the positive side of migration, that highlight the Venezuelan professionals and hard workers contributing here, that remind people we are human beings who lost everything and are simply trying to start again. Empathy grows when people hear our real stories, when they understand that no one leaves their homeland, their language, and everyone they love without the most desperate of reasons.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to save enough money to start my own small construction business one day, and to be able to hire other migrants who need work and a fair employer who will not exploit their vulnerability the way I was exploited. I dream of stability above all else, of a home that is truly ours, of my children graduating from school and having the kind of future that Venezuela, in its collapse, could never have offered them. And somewhere in my heart I still hold the hope that if things change, if the situation back home improves, I might one day be able to visit my homeland again, to see the places and people I was forced to leave behind.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: To newcomers I say: work honestly and keep your head down while you build your reputation, because your reputation is the most valuable thing you have when you arrive with nothing else. Get your papers and your legal status in order as soon as you possibly can, because legality is what protects you from exploitation and gives you access to a real life. Do not respond to insults with violence or anger, however much they provoke you; instead, prove them wrong through the quality of your work and the integrity of your conduct. And always, always remember why you came, hold onto the image of your family, because on the hardest days that memory is what will keep you going.